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CENTERPIECE

St. Mary's watershed group, volunteers plant one million oysters

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Larry O'Brien, vice president of the St. Mary's Watershed Association, stacks bags full of baby oysters onto a boat at the Oyster Sanctuary on Saturday. Community members and volunteers met at Abells Wharf to plant one million oysters.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

Volunteers at Abells Wharf on Saturday had two jobs: form a line on the dock to pass bags of oysters into a boat and then plant the oysters into the Breton Bay Oyster Sanctuary.

Since 2017, St. Mary's River Watershed Association and Friends of St. Clement's Bay have been working to rebuild a healthy oyster population in the bay located within St. Mary's County off the Potomac River, Emma Ewing, executive director of the St. Mary's Watershed Association, said.

"Breton Bay has had a huge loss," Ewing said. "We believe that no oysters is the exact reason why we should be restoring oysters in Breton Bay."

Community group members and volunteers unloaded around 500 bags of baby oysters to transport them by boat to release them off Lover's Point in Breton Bay, a release from the watershed association said.

"It makes a big difference," Chuck Stickney, a volunteer at Saturday's event, said. "The water keeps getting clearer and clearer here."

In 2023, the watershed association saw natural spat — small oyster larvae attached to an oyster shell — in the bay for the first time in two decades, Ewing said. This year, they saw reproduction again.

The watershed fills a nursery tank at St. Mary's College of Maryland with power-washed oyster shells with circulated river water for two days, Ewing said. Then they place 2.5 million oyster larvae from Horn Point Oyster Hatchery on the Eastern Shore into the tank.

They wait two days for them to attach to the oyster shell before turning back on the circulated river water so they can eat the algae.

“When I was a kid, the oysters in Breton Bay were in such demand, it was hard to get them,” Larry O’Brien, vice president of the St. Mary’s Watershed Association, said.

In the Chesapeake Bay, oysters “play a large role in supporting other aquatic life and the health of an ecosystem,” the release said.

Oysters filter the water and build reefs where striped bass, blue crabs and other animals take refuge. Maryland designated many Chesapeake Bay tributaries, including Breton Bay, oyster sanctuaries to protect the population and make oyster harvest limited.

State and federal partners had Breton Bay on the list for restoration, but it was revoked in 2018 due to low oyster population, poor water quality and lack of annual oyster reproduction, the release said. Community groups decided to step up and encourage future investment.

“What we’re doing here is working,” Ewing said. “We are restoring the oyster population.”

